Figure Out Who Is Really Doing What in Your Father's Care Right Now

Four prompts to list everyone involved, find the tasks nobody owns, see what's landing on one person, and sort which questions go to whom.

Where you are

Your father's care arrangement grew one favor at a time. Your sister handles the pharmacy, a neighbor drives, you call the facility, and nobody is sure who follows up when something changes. Last week a task went unhandled because everyone thought someone else had it.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can name who does each task today, which tasks have no owner, and which questions need a clinician rather than a family coordinator.

A one-page care team snapshot: Who Is Involved, Tasks With an Owner, Tasks Without an Owner, Questions for a Clinician, and Questions for a Care Consultant.

Before you start

- Names of the people involved in your father's care, family and professional.
- A rough list of the things that have to happen each week.
- Any contact sheet or phone list from the provider, if there is one. If you only have two of these, start anyway.

PROMPT 1

List everyone and what they actually do

WHY THIS MATTERS

Care arrangements grow by favors. After a few months nobody has a complete list, and the person who thinks they know is usually missing someone.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Names or roles of everyone who touches your father's care, and what you think each one does.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My father has a care arrangement that several people share. Here is everyone I can think of, family and professional, and what I believe each one does:

> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Turn this into a table with four columns: PERSON OR ROLE, WHAT THEY DO, HOW OFTEN, and HOW SURE I AM (confirmed, assumed, or guessing). Keep family members and professionals in separate sections. Where I've written something vague like 'helps out,' put a question mark in the second column instead of inventing a task. At the end, list anyone I mentioned without saying what they do.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The rows marked 'assumed' or 'guessing.' Those are the conversations you need to have.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Call or text the people in the assumed rows and ask them what they actually do.

PROMPT 2

Find the tasks nobody owns

WHY THIS MATTERS

The task that went wrong last week probably didn't belong to anyone. Listing the work separately from the people shows you the holes.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The table from prompt 1 and a list of the recurring tasks in your father's week.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the table of who is involved in my father's care:
>
> [PASTE THE TABLE FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> And here are the recurring tasks and decisions I can think of, such as refilling prescriptions, rides to appointments, calling the facility, paying bills, and checking in on him:
>
> [PASTE YOUR TASK LIST]
>
> Match each task to the person who does it now. Give me three lists: TASKS WITH A CLEAR OWNER, TASKS WITH NO OWNER, and TASKS WHERE TWO PEOPLE MIGHT BOTH THINK IT'S THEIRS. For each task, add whether anyone could step in if the usual person were sick for a week. Do not suggest who should take the unowned tasks. I'll ask the family that myself.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Unowned tasks and tasks with no backup, especially the ones that involve a deadline.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick the unowned task with the nearest deadline and ask, not assign, who can take it.

PROMPT 3

Check what is landing on one person

WHY THIS MATTERS

Usually one person is quietly carrying most of it, and they may not say so. Seeing the hours in a list is often the first time anyone, including that person, notices.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The lists from prompt 2, and an honest guess at how many hours each task takes.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the care tasks in my father's arrangement and who does each one, with a rough estimate of hours per week:
>
> [PASTE THE LISTS FROM PROMPT 2 WITH YOUR HOUR ESTIMATES]
>
> Add up the estimated hours per person and show me a short table: PERSON, TASKS, and ROUGH HOURS PER WEEK. Then tell me which person carries the most, which of their tasks would be easiest to hand to someone else given the skill and location involved, and which tasks really need to stay with them. Phrase this as options for a family conversation, not as a new assignment. Don't comment on whether anyone is doing enough.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

One name with far more hours than anyone else, and a few tasks that don't actually need to be theirs.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show that person the table and ask what they would hand off if they could.

PROMPT 4

Sort the questions by who should answer them

WHY THIS MATTERS

A family coordinator can arrange rides and track paperwork. They cannot change a medication or decide a treatment. Mixing those up is how families get hurt and how clinicians stop returning calls.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts and your open questions about your father's care.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've put together about my father's care team, plus the questions that are still open:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3 AND YOUR OPEN QUESTIONS]
>
> Make me a one-page care team snapshot with five headings: WHO IS INVOLVED, TASKS WITH AN OWNER, TASKS WITHOUT AN OWNER, QUESTIONS FOR A CLINICIAN, and QUESTIONS FOR A CARE CONSULTANT. Under the last two headings, sort my open questions. Anything about medications, treatment, diagnosis, or whether he is safe goes to a clinician. Anything about who does what, scheduling, or how the family works together goes to a care consultant. Do not answer the clinical questions. If a question is about who has legal authority to decide for him, mark it 'needs clarification' and leave it there.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that separates the family's work from the clinicians' work, with nothing decided that shouldn't be.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the snapshot where the family can see it, then take the next step below.

See the whole picture before you divide the work

A care team plan only works if everyone is working from the same understanding of your father's needs. The care interview organizes his situation area by area into a Family Care Profile the whole team can start from.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›